

FAVORITISM

WHAT FAVORITISM
ACTUALLY IS



CHOOSING SOMEONE BECAUSE YOU LIKE THEM NOT BECAUSE THEY EARNED IT.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

What Favoritism Actually Is

← You are here

02

The Hard Truths

Coming up.

03

What the Coach Is Actually Sees

Coming up.

04

The Athlete's Blind Spot

Coming up.

05

The Solution You Can Control

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

MOST OF WHAT PARENTS
CALL FAVORITISM
IS NOT FAVORITISM.
IT'S COACHABILITY.
AND THAT'S FIXABLE.

Favoritism means choosing someone based on feelings instead of behavior, effort, or execution toward a predefined standard. That's not what's usually happening.

— DEFINE IT BEFORE YOU JUDGE IT

THE DEFINITION

FAVORITISM VS. TRUST-BASED SELECTION.

→ Favoritism: choosing based on personal feelings, relationships, or bias

→ Trust-based selection: choosing based on demonstrated consistent performance and coachability

→ The question is not 'does the coach like her?' The question is 'has she earned trust?'

— RANDOM WOULD BE FAVORITISM. TRUST IS PROOF OF SOMETHING.

05 · THE HARD TRUTH

WHAT THE DATA USUALLY SHOWS

THE STARTING SIX

Those players didn't get picked randomly. They built a track record of trust.

THE UTILITY ROLE

Athletes who fill multiple positions have demonstrated range and adaptability — that earns opportunity.

THE FEEDBACK LOOP

The athlete who shows up for feedback, applies it, and builds on it accumulates trust over time.



06 · WHY IT FEELS LIKE FAVORITISM

THE PERCEPTION GAP

PARENT LENS VS. COACH LENS

You see talent. The coach sees coachability, consistency, and trust. Both are real — they're different metrics.



INFORMATION GAP

You don't see practice. The coach does. Much of what drives decisions lives there.

EMOTIONAL INVESTMENT

When your athlete isn't playing, the brain naturally looks for an external explanation.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

IS IT FAVORITISM?
OR IS IT TRUST
SHE HASN'T EARNED YET?
THE ANSWER CHANGES
EVERYTHING ABOUT
WHAT TO DO NEXT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— DEFINE IT BEFORE YOU JUDGE IT

THIS WEEK

GET HONEST ABOUT THE QUESTION THIS WEEK.

- ✓ Write down exactly what makes you believe favoritism is happening.
- ✓ For each item, ask: could this also be explained by trust, consistency, or coachability?
- ✓ Ask your athlete: what does your coach see from you at practice that you'd want to change?
- ✓ Decide: is this a favoritism problem or a coachability opportunity?



The Hard Truths

02

THESE LAND DIFFERENTLY WHEN YOU LET THEM.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

HARD TRUTH:
THE COACH MADE
A DECISION.
YOUR DAUGHTER
WASN'T CHOSEN.
RANDOM WOULD
HAVE BEEN FAVORITISM.
TRUST IS PROOF.

Let the emotions rise. Let them settle. Then come back and look at these with logic.

— LET THE EMOTION LAND. THEN BRING THE LOGIC.

THE HARD TRUTHS

THREE TRUTHS THAT CHANGE THE RESPONSE.

- The starting six earned their spot through a pattern of behavior not a single moment
- Coaches are stretched thin and gravitate toward athletes who make the investment feel returned
- The athlete has more control over this outcome than anyone in the stands does

— THE TRUTH THAT HURTS IS USUALLY THE MOST USEFUL ONE.

05 · HARD TRUTH 1

THE DECISION WAS MADE ON EVIDENCE

WHAT EVIDENCE?

Every practice, every feedback response, every moment of pressure the coach has been building a file.



THE FILE

Your athlete's file currently says something. The question is what it says and who's responsible for it.

THE OPPORTUNITY

If the file was built by behavior, it can be rebuilt by different behavior.



06 · HARD TRUTH 2

YOUR DAUGHTER'S ROLE

SHE IS NOT A PASSIVE RECIPIENT

The dynamic between her and her coach has been co-created.

WHERE HER POWER LIVES

In her feedback response, her practice consistency, her non-verbal signals — all of it.

THE WORK

Three weeks of different behavior starts to change what the coach files.

02



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE PARENT WHO
CAN HOLD THE HARD TRUTH
WITHOUT COLLAPSING
CAN ACTUALLY HELP
THEIR ATHLETE CHANGE
THE OUTCOME.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— TRUTH IS THE STARTING POINT

THIS WEEK

SIT WITH THE HARD TRUTHS THIS WEEK

- ✓ Write down the hard truth that's hardest to accept in your situation.
- ✓ Ask: what is my athlete's role in creating this situation?
- ✓ Ask: what would I have to believe for this to be fixable?
- ✓ Share one hard truth with your athlete gently, without blame, as a starting point.

WHAT THE COACH IS ACTUALLY SEEING

03

YOU SEE THE MATCH. THE COACH SEES PRACTICE. THAT'S WHERE DECISIONS LIVE.



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MOST PLAYING TIME
DECISIONS ARE MADE
AT PRACTICE.
NOT AT MATCHES.

You see the competition. The coach sees the 80% of the iceberg that lives at practice and that's the part that determines the starting six.

— DECISIONS LIVE AT PRACTICE

THE PRACTICE ICEBERG

WHAT YOU SEE VS. WHAT THE COACH SEES.

- Match performance: visible to everyone, reactive, often reflects practice patterns
- Practice behavior: invisible to parents, proactive, where trust and coachability are built
- The coach's file: 80% practice, 20% competition

— IF YOU WANT TO CHANGE THE OUTCOME, CHANGE THE PRACTICE.

05 · WHAT COACHES SEE AT PRACTICE

THE INVISIBLE DATA

FEEDBACK RESPONSE

Does she try to apply it in the next rep? Or does it evaporate?

DRILL CONSISTENCY

Is she locked in on rep 30 the same way she was on rep 1?

NON-VERBAL ENERGY

Eye contact with the coach, physical posture, the energy she brings to each station.



06 · THE PARENT BLINDSPOT

WHAT YOU'RE MISSING

YOU'RE NOT THERE

Practice is where the decisions are made and you're not in the room.

YOUR ATHLETE'S REPORT

Her version of practice may not match what the coach experiences.

THE QUESTION TO ASK

Instead of 'what is coach doing?' ask 'what is my athlete doing at practice?'



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE DECISION WAS
MADE AT PRACTICE.
THE MATCH JUST
CONFIRMED IT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— PRACTICE IS WHERE IT HAPPENS



THIS WEEK

GET CURIOUS ABOUT PRACTICE THIS WEEK.

- ✓ Ask your athlete: what does your coach see from you at practice?
- ✓ Ask: in the last 5 practices, how many times did you apply feedback in the very next rep?
- ✓ If her coach allows it, ask for one piece of specific practice feedback — then act on it.
- ✓ Watch what changes at the next competition when the practice behavior changes first.



FAVORITISM

THE ATHLETE'S BLIND SPOT



SHE CAN'T SEE WHAT THE COACH SEES. UNTIL SOMEONE SHOWS HER.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

SHE THINKS SHE'S
COACHABLE.
THE COACH HAS
A DIFFERENT FILE.

This gap between how an athlete sees herself and how the coach sees her is where most playing time frustration lives.

— THE GAP BETWEEN PERCEPTION AND REALITY IS THE WORK

THE BLIND SPOT

WHAT SHE THINKS VS. WHAT THE COACH SEES.

→ She thinks: 'I work hard and the coach doesn't see it'

→ Coach sees: inconsistent response to feedback, external regulation, variable effort

→ The gap: she's measuring effort; the coach is measuring coachability and trust

— YOU CAN'T CLOSE A GAP YOU CAN'T SEE.

05 · COMMON BLIND SPOTS

WHAT ATHLETES MISS

THE GEN Z STARE

Receiving feedback without visible acknowledgement reads as disrespect to coaches even when it isn't.

BODY LANGUAGE

Shoulders down, avoiding eye contact, slow to reset these signal things the athlete doesn't intend.

THE EXPLANATION HABIT

Explaining why a mistake happened instead of resetting forward. Coaches read it as defensiveness.



06 · CLOSING THE GAP

HOW TO HELP HER SEE IT

VIDEO REVIEW

If available, watch practice footage together without judgment.

THE MIRROR QUESTION

Ask: if you were the coach and you saw yourself today, what would you think?

ONE TARGET BEHAVIOR

Pick one blind spot to work on per week. Not all of them. One.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE ATHLETE WHO
CAN SEE HERSELF
THROUGH THE COACH'S
EYES HAS A MASSIVE
ADVANTAGE OVER THE
ONE WHO CAN'T.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

—SEE THE GAP TO CLOSE IT

THIS WEEK

FIND THE BLIND SPOT THIS WEEK.

✓ Ask your athlete: if you were the coach, what would your file say about you right now?

✓ Have her list three things the coach sees that she'd want to change.

✓ Pick one to work on this week.

✓ Check in after 5 practices: is it shifting?



THE SOLUTION YOU CAN CONTROL

OS

THERE IS ALWAYS SOMETHING YOU CAN DO. IT STARTS WITH THE ATHLETE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

YOU CANNOT CHANGE
THE COACH'S DECISION.
YOU CAN CHANGE
WHAT THE COACH
FILES NEXT.

The solution lives where the athlete has control not where the parent has frustration.

— CONTROL YOUR INPUT, NOT THE OUTPUT

THE SOLUTION

THREE THINGS.
THREE WEEKS.
ONE COMMITMENT.

→ Week 1: change feedback response visible acknowledgement every time, no exceptions

→ Week 2: add consistent practice energy same effort on rep 30 as rep 1

→ Week 3: own the non-verbal eye contact, posture, resetting forward after mistakes

— THREE WEEKS OF DIFFERENT INPUTS STARTS TO CHANGE THE FILE.

05 · FOR THE PARENT

WHERE YOUR ENERGY GOES

NOT TO THE COACH

Approaching the coach to discuss favoritism while the athlete is doing the work contradicts the entire message.

TO THE PROCESS

Coach the behaviors, not the volleyball. Help her practice the three things off the court.

TO THE LONG GAME

Trust that consistent different behavior over a full season rewrites what the coach files.



06 · MEASURING IT

HOW TO KNOW IT'S WORKING

3 WEEKS

The coach begins to invest differently. More feedback means more trust building.

6 WEEKS

Playing time changes begin to reflect the new pattern.

FULL SEASON

The athlete owns her spot not because the coach changed, but because she did.

02

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

SHE CANNOT CONTROL
THE COACH'S DECISION.
SHE CAN CONTROL
EVERY INPUT THAT
GOES INTO MAKING IT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— CONTROL THE INPUT

THIS WEEK

LAUNCH THE THREE-WEEK SOLUTION.

- ✓ Week 1: one visible acknowledgement after every piece of feedback track it.
- ✓ Week 2: bring identical effort to every single drill for five straight practices.
- ✓ Week 3: work on non-verbal signals eye contact, posture, reset pace after mistakes.
- ✓ Week 4: evaluate the coach's investment. Has it shifted? What drove the shift?

